

ŚŪNYAVĀDA

The Mādhyamika School — Nāgārjuna and the Doctrine of Emptiness

Source: C. D. Sharma — A Critical Survey of Indian Philosophy, Chapter Six

These notes cover the complete philosophical argument of Chapter Six with zero semantic compression: Aśvaghoṣa's proto-Mahāyāna, the precise double meaning of Śūnya, the Māhāyāna-Sūtras' destructive dialectic (Nāgārjuna's eight No-s, critique of causation/motion/skandhas/ego/time/Nirvāṇa), the constructive dialectic (two standpoints, Prajñā-pāramitā, four Meditations, ten Stages of Bodhisattvahood), Nāgārjuna's refutation of opponents in the Vighraha-Vyāvarttanī, Chandrakīrti's critique of Diṅnāga, and Śāntideva's synthesis — all arguments in full.

I. Aśvaghoṣa — The First Systematic Expounder of Mahāyāna

Historical Position and the Mahāyānashraddhotpāda-śāstra

Aśvaghoṣa's great philosophical work, the Mahāyānashraddhotpāda-śāstra ("Awakening of Faith in the Mahāyāna"), exists only in Chinese translation (by Paramārtha; English translations by D.T. Suzuki and T. Richard). His authorship is disputed — Takakusu and Winternitz deny it; Suzuki defends it with strong arguments from the Chinese tradition. Aśvaghoṣa's purpose: to unfold the fundamental teaching of the Tathāgata against the errors of laymen (pṛthag-jana), Hīnayānists (Śrāvakas), and Pratyekabuddhas. Nāgārjuna is only the first systematic expositor of Śūnyavāda — he did not found it; the threads were already present in pre-Aśvaghoṣa Mahāyāna Sūtras.

Aśvaghoṣa's Ontology: The Structure of Reality (Tathatā)

Reality is Tathatā (Suchness). It receives different names according to the viewpoint adopted:

- Bhūtatahatā — as ultimate Existence
- Bodhi or Prajñā or Ālayavijñāna — as Pure Spirit
- Dharmakāya or Dharmadhātu — as Harmonious Whole
- Tathāgatagarbha — as Bliss having infinite merits
- Saṃsāra — viewed from the empirical standpoint (cycle of birth and death)
- Nirvāṇa — viewed from the ultimate standpoint (positive bliss)

Reality is essentially Indescribable because intellect cannot compass it. It is beyond the four categories (catuṣkoṭi) of understanding: it is neither existence nor non-existence, nor both, nor neither; neither unity nor plurality, nor both, nor neither; neither affirmation nor negation, nor both, nor neither. When it is said that worldly things are unreal, what is meant is that they are only phenomenally real. The Absolute is the ultimate Reality; all phenomena are merely relative. Relativity (pratītyasamutpāda) is the work of Ignorance.

Ignorance, Intellect, and the Absolute

Ignorance has no existence of its own, yet is not entirely unreal — it produces the objective world. It is wrong to take the work of Ignorance as ultimate and forget the foundation on which it stands. Relational intellect cannot give us Reality. Āśvaghoṣa: "When one can apprehend that which is behind discursive thought, one is on the way to Buddhist Wisdom."

The Tathāgata uses words and definitions only provisionally (upāya-kausālya) — to lead beings to abandon symbolism and directly enter Reality. But intellect must not be annihilated: "If we dispense with finite enlightenment, we cannot conceive of true enlightenment." It is Reason itself which appears as intellect. The Absolute itself through Ignorance appears as this manifold phenomenal world.

Key analogy: Calm water on account of wind appears as waves; similarly consciousness (Vijñāna), on account of Ignorance, appears as finite intellects. Just as clay is transformed into various kinds of pottery, similarly One Consciousness manifests as many finite intellects. Absolute Suchness ultimately transcends everything; tainted with Ignorance it manifests as Conditional Suchness. Our phenomenal world — subjective as well as objective — is the result of the sport of Conditional Suchness. When true knowledge dawns we realize we are no more finite beings but Absolute Suchness itself: the self-existent, immortal, Calm and Blissful Reality.

Historical Significance: Āśvaghoṣa as Root of All Mahāyāna Schools

There is hardly any important doctrine in any school of Mahāyāna which cannot be traced back to Āśvaghoṣa. Specifically:

- The point that Reality is Indescribable and beyond all categories — that it can be called neither Śūnya nor Aśūnya nor both nor neither — was developed by Śūnyavāda.
- The point that Reality is Consciousness (pure spirit, Bodhi, Ālayavijñāna) was developed by Vijñānavāda.

II. Śūnyavāda — The School and the True Meaning of 'Śūnya'

Nāgārjuna's Place: Systematic Expositor, Not Founder

Śūnyavāda is one of the most important schools of Buddhism. Nāgārjuna cannot be called its founder because it was present before him in the Mahāyāna Sūtras, some of which pre-date even Aśvaghoṣa. Nāgārjuna's glory lies in seizing these scattered threads and weaving them into a unified, thoroughly consistent system. Śūnyavādins call themselves Mādhyamikas — followers of the Middle Path realized by Buddha during Enlightenment — which avoids the errors of existence and non-existence, affirmation and negation, eternalism and nihilism, and at once transcends both extremes. It is a great irony that followers of such a path are condemned as nihilists.

The Philosophical Meaning of 'Śūnya' — A Four-Part Clarification

The word 'Śūnya' has been gravely misunderstood. Its literal meaning — negation or void — has caused thinkers Eastern and Western, ancient medieval and modern, to commit the horrible blunder of condemning Śūnyavāda as hopeless scepticism or self-condemned nihilism. The Mādhyamikas emphatically maintain that Śūnya does NOT mean 'nothing', 'empty void', or 'negative abyss'. Its four-part philosophical meaning is:

- Indescribable (avācya or anabhilāpya) — because Reality is beyond the four categories of intellect (catuṣkoṭi-vinirmukta). It is Reality which ultimately transcends existence, non-existence, both and neither. It is neither affirmation nor negation nor both nor neither.
- Relativity (pratītyasamutpāda) — empirically, Śūnya means phenomena or Saṃsāra. That which is phenomenal, dependent, conditional and therefore relative cannot be called ultimately real, just as borrowed wealth cannot be called real capital. Appearances (dharmas) being relative (pratītyasamutpanna) have no real origination (paramārthato nutpanna) and are therefore devoid of ultimate reality (svabhāva-śūnya or nissvabhāva or anātman). But they are not absolutely unreal — they must belong to Reality.
- Reality (tattva) — absolutely, Śūnya means release from plurality (nirvāṇa). It is the Real itself which appears. The Real is the Absolute, the Non-dual Harmonious Whole in which all plurality is merged (prapañchaśūnya or niṣprapañcha or advaya tattva).
- Double meaning simultaneously — Śūnya means the relative AND the Absolute, Relativity AND Reality, Saṃsāra AND Nirvāṇa. Appearances are Svabhāva-śūnya (devoid of ultimate reality); Reality is Prapañcha-śūnya (devoid of plurality).

It is clearly wrong to translate 'Śūnya' as 'nothing or void'; and even to translate it as 'Relativity' as Prof. Stcherbatsky has done, is but to represent

only one aspect of it.

Aśvaghoṣa said that Tathatā is neither Śūnya nor Aśūnya nor both nor neither, because it transcends all categories. 'All things in the world from beginning are neither matter nor mind (empirical ego), nor consciousness (momentary and individual), nor non-being, nor being; they are after all, inexplicable.' But this does not mean there is no reality — it is the Real itself which appears. 'The divine nature of Absolute Reality is not unreal.'

The Eternalist and Nihilist Errors

Those who maintain the world exists commit a great error: penetrating deep, we find the entire world is essentially relative and therefore ultimately unreal. Those who advocate non-existence are also committing a great error: they deny even the phenomenal reality of the world and are condemned as nihilists (nāstikas). Intellect — essentially discursive, analytic, relational — involves itself in contradictions. All that can be grasped by intellect is essentially relative, giving four categories (existence, non-existence, both, neither) and involving itself in sixty-two antinomies. It cannot give us Reality. Reality transcends all categories, reconciles all antinomies, and is to be directly realized through spiritual experience. We must rise above subject-object duality and the plurality of phenomena.

III. Mahāyāna-Sūtras: The Destructive Dialectic

The Saddharma-puṇḍarīka-Sūtra

Not knowing that in the reign of intellect Relativity holds sway; not knowing that everything phenomenal is dependent ('this being, that arises' = Dependent Origination) — people, like blind-born men, go on revolving in the wheel of Birth-and-Death that is Saṃsāra. He who knows that all empirical dharmas are Śūnya (devoid of self-reality) knows the supreme wisdom of the Buddhas. He who knows that all worldly objects are like illusion and dreams, essenceless like a plantain trunk, only echoes of Reality, that there is neither bondage nor release, that all dharmas are absolutely equal, that in fact difference does not exist, knows the truth and attains to immortal blissful Nirvāṇa.

The Aṣṭasāhasrikā Prajñāpāramitā — Systematic Destruction

It is declared again and again that no object of thought can resist ultimate scrutiny. Every phenomenal object, when taken to be ultimately real, will be found self-contradictory or śūnya — the mere fact that it is an object of finite intellect proves it has only conditional relative existence. The destructive dialectic delivers:

- The five skandhas are an illusion. There is no 'person' that can be liberated nor is there any doctrine by which he may be liberated; there is no 'person' that can be

bound nor is there anything by which he may be bound.

- The 'thinghood' of a thing is an illusion. Nothing has an origination. There is no element, no person, no dharma.
- Mahāyāna is a self-contradiction. Nirvāṇa is an illusion. Even if there is anything greater than Nirvāṇa, that too will be only an illusion.
- A Bodhisattva is a mere dream. Even the Buddha is only a name. Even Perfect Wisdom itself is a mere name.
- Dreams, echoes, reflections, images, mirage, illusion, magic, void — such are all objects of intellect.
- The Śatasāhasrikā Prajñāpāramitā condemns all dharmas as illusory. They have neither origination nor decay, they neither increase nor decrease, they are neither suffering nor its cessation, neither affirmation nor negation, neither eternal nor momentary, neither śūnya nor aśūnya. They are mere names and forms (Māyā).

Māyā is declared to be an inconsistent category which cannot resist dialectical scrutiny and which is ultimately found to be neither existent nor non-existent. All phenomena are mere names; they are only a convention, a usage, a practical compromise.

The Laṅkāvatāra condemns phenomena to be like an illusion, a dream, a mirage, a hare's horn, a barren woman's son, a magic city, a double moon, a moving fire-brand presenting an appearance of a circle, a hair seen floating in the atmosphere by defective vision, an empty space, a sky-flower, a mere echo, a reflection, a painting, a puppet-like mechanism — which can be called neither existent nor non-existent. The Lalitavistara, Samādhirāja, and Suvarṇaprabhāsa join in such descriptions.

The Laṅkāvatāra on Intellect (Tarka) vs. Spiritual Experience (Prajñā)

Intellect gives us discrimination (vikalpa) and dualism (dvaita), not Reality. The entire phenomenal practices of the world depend on the four categories of intellect. Those entangled in intellect are worse than dogs and can never know the Real. Just as elephants are stuck in deep mud, so are fools entangled in language, in letters, words and names.

Consciousness (jñāna) has two aspects:

- Intellect (tarka) — proceeds with subject-object duality; relational, discursive
- Spiritual experience (prajñā) — enables realization of the Formless and Unqualified Absolute; non-dual, direct

All the contradictory pairs — 'everything has a cause' and 'nothing has a cause'; 'everything is eternal' and 'everything is momentary'; 'everything is unity' and 'everything is plurality'; 'everything is expressible' and 'everything is inexpressible'; 'soul exists' and 'soul does not exist'; 'matter exists' and 'matter does not exist'; 'the other world exists' and 'the other world does not exist'; 'there is liberation' and 'there

is no liberation' — all this is gross and crude philosophy (lokāyata). In real philosophy we have to transcend the categories of intellect.

The Revolution from Hīnayāna to Mahāyāna

The change is a revolution across five paired dimensions:

Hīnayāna Position	Mahāyāna Position
Radical pluralism (dharmavāda)	Radical Absolutism (advayavāda)
Dogmatism (dṛṣṭivāda)	Criticism / scepticism (śūnyavāda)
Plurality of momentary elements (dharmavāda)	Essential unity underlying them (dharma-tāvāda)
Unreality of eternal substance (pudgala-nairātmya)	Unreality of all elements (dharma-nairātmya)
Momentary atoms / momentary ideas	Transcendental Absolute as the Real

IV. Śūnyavāda: Nāgārjuna's Destructive Dialectic

Before the mighty strokes of the destructive dialectic of Nāgārjuna and his commentator Chandrakīrti, the entire structure of phenomenal objects crumbles down like a house of cards or a palace on sand. External objects, the individual subject, matter, motion, causality, time, space, thinghood, qualities, relation, attributes, substance, soul, God, religion, morality, the four Noble Truths, Nirvāṇa, and the Buddha — all are found to be hypostatized relations. But from the empirical viewpoint they are all quite real, though ultimately they are all merged in the bosom of the Absolute.

A. The Eight 'No'-s: The Opening Salvo of the Mādhyamika-Kārikā

In the very first stanza of the Mādhyamika-Kārikā, Nāgārjuna gives his famous eight 'No'-s:

From the absolute standpoint there is neither destruction nor production, neither nihilism nor eternalism, neither unity nor plurality, neither coming in nor going out.

He then salutes Buddha as the perfectly Enlightened and the greatest of all teachers, who taught Pratītyasamutpāda which, viewed from the absolute standpoint, is blissful Nirvāṇa itself wherein all plurality is merged.

B. The Doctrine of No-Origination (Anutpāda)

Never and nowhere can anything be produced. A thing can originate neither out of itself nor out of a not-self nor out of both nor out of neither. Nāgārjuna's four-fold

refutation:

- Not out of itself (sva-utpāda): If the effect is already existent in its cause, it is already an existing fact requiring no further production; if the effect does not exist in its cause, nothing can produce it — for nothing can produce a hare's horn or a barren woman's son.
- Not out of a not-self (para-utpāda): If a thing cannot arise out of itself, how can it arise out of a not-self?
- Not out of both: To say a thing can arise out of both itself and not-self is to maintain that light and darkness can remain together — a self-contradiction.
- Not at random / uncaused (ahetuka): Certainly nothing can arise at random and uncaused.

Chandrakīrti gives similar arguments.

C. Refutation of the Four Conditions (Pratyaya) of Hīnayāna

Nāgārjuna examines and destroys each of the four Hīnayāna conditions:

- Hetu (producing cause): An impossibility. A cause has no essence — because neither an existent thing, nor a non-existent thing, nor a thing which is both, can be produced. A cause without essence is like a hare's horn.
- Ālambana (object): If in the beginning a subject arises independently of an object, how can that subject afterwards depend on its objective counterpart?
- Samanantara (immediately preceding moment): When things do not exist, how can they disappear? Therefore there can be no immediately preceding moment. Moreover, if an immediately preceding moment disappears, how can it be a cause? If a seed is destroyed, what is that which will be called the cause of a sprout?
- Adhipati (decisive factor): If things are relative, they cannot have independent existence or ultimate reality. A thing which is not real can be neither produced nor destroyed. So the formula 'this being, that arises' (asmin sati idam bhavati) becomes nonsense.

Hence in none of these four pratyayas, neither singly nor jointly, can we find the so-called 'effect'. If the effect pre-exists in the cause, then milk should be called curd and threads should be called cloth. If the effect does not pre-exist, then curd should be produced out of water and cloth out of reeds. Both cause and effect are relative and therefore causality is only an appearance, not reality.

D. Motion is Impossible

A trilemma about the path:

- We cannot travel a path which has already been travelled (it is already finished).
- Nor can we travel a path which has not yet been travelled (it does not yet exist as a path).

- A path which has neither been travelled nor is yet to be travelled is also not being travelled.

The mover does not move; the non-mover of course does not move. What is that third, which is neither a mover nor a non-mover, which can move? Hence motion, mover, and destination are all unreal. Similarly, the seer, the seen, and the sight are also unreal.

E. The Five Skandhas are Unreal

Each skandha destroyed by the same causal argument:

- Rūpa (matter): If matter exists, it can have no cause because it is already existent; if it does not exist then too it can have no cause because a non-entity like a hare's horn cannot be caused; and uncaused matter is impossible. So matter is unreal.
- Vedanā (feeling), Saṃjñā (conception), Saṃskāra (forces), Vijñāna (individual consciousness): All unreal by the same argument.
- The four elements — earth, water, fire, air, and space — are all unreal.

We know only attributes or qualities; we do not know the substance or the thing. Without attributes we cannot know a substance; without a substance, attributes cannot exist. But attributes exist neither in the substance nor outside it. Where then can they exist? Substance and attributes are neither the same nor different — both are therefore relative and unreal. Production, continuance, and destruction cannot characterize a composite substance (saṃskṛta) either singly or jointly. Production is impossible because nothing can originate. And if there is no production, how can there be continuance and destruction?

F. The Individual Self is Unreal

The self (Ego) is neither identical with nor different from the five skandhas. Buddha's teaching is Dependent Origination which is relativity — neither eternalism nor nihilism. Neither those who uphold the identity of the individual self and the skandhas, nor those who advocate their difference, know the real teaching of Buddha.

- If the Ego is the same as the skandhas, it too, like them, will be subject to birth and death.
- If the Ego is different from the skandhas, it cannot be known.

When the 'I' and the 'mine' cease to function, the entire structure of the universe — subjective as well as objective — crumbles to the ground. The skandhas no more operate. The cycle of birth and death comes to a stand-still.

G. The Universe: Beginningless, Endless, and Unreal

Buddha said the universe is beginningless and endless. It is an accepted canon of logic, urges Nāgārjuna, that if a thing does not exist in the beginning and in the end, it cannot exist in the middle also. Hence beginning, middle, and end; birth,

persistence, and death are all unreal. Not only the universe is beginningless — all objects of intellect are equally beginningless and hence middleless and endless.

H. Change is Impossible

A dilemma about change:

- If the changeless does not exist, what is it that changes?
- If a thing is changeless, how can it change?
- If Reality does not exist, what is that which appears?
- If it is Reality, how can it be an appearance?

I. Subject-Object Relation, Action, Time — All Unreal

The subject, the object, and the subject-object relation are unreal. Action and its result are also unreal: if action really exists, it will be eternal and actionless, then all phenomenal practices will collapse. Suffering, actions, bodies, doers, results — all are like an illusion, a magic city, a dream, a mirage. Time is also unreal because past, present, and future are all relative.

J. Even the Buddha (Tathāgata) is an Illusion

Even the Buddha, the Tathāgata, is only an illusion. He is neither identical with nor different from the skandhas. He is really Śūnya. We cannot say whether he exists or does not exist or does both or neither, either after Nirvāṇa or even during lifetime. He transcends all categories of finite thought.

K. The Fourteen Antinomies — Insoluble by Intellect

Intellect gives rise to the famous fourteen antinomies which Buddha answered by silence. Nāgārjuna says these are all relative and therefore mere appearances, insoluble by intellect:

- (1-4) Whether the world is finite (antavān) or not or both or neither.
- (5-8) Whether the world is permanent (śāśvata) or not or both or neither.
- (9-12) Whether the Tathāgata after Nirvāṇa is existent or not or both or neither.
- (13-14) Whether matter and mind are identical or not.

L. The Four Noble Truths, Three Jewels — Also Unreal

There is neither suffering nor its cause nor its cessation nor the way towards its cessation. The three Jewels are also unreal. There is neither the Order, nor the Religion, nor the Buddha. Nirvāṇa itself is an illusion. Bondage and release are relative and therefore unreal. Neither the forces nor the ego can be either bound or liberated.

- Neither that which is the skandhas nor that which is not the skandhas can be either bound or liberated.

- Neither that which is bound nor that which is unbound nor that which is both nor that which is neither can be either bound or liberated.
- He who thinks: 'Transcending the five skandhas, I shall obtain liberation,' is still entangled in the terrible clutches of the skandhas themselves.
- There is no bondage and consequently no liberation. Both are relative and hence unreal.

When neither Saṃsāra is destroyed nor Nirvāṇa is attained, why should Saṃsāra and Nirvāṇa be at all imagined?

M. The Self-Contradiction of Nirvāṇa

Nāgārjuna subjects Nirvāṇa itself to the catuṣkoṭi — the four-cornered destruction:

- Nirvāṇa cannot be existence: Then like other existing things it will be subject to birth and death; it will have a cause and will be based on the skandhas like all other Saṃskṛta dharmas.
- Nirvāṇa cannot be non-existence: Non-existence necessarily depends upon existence; it will not be independent.
- Nirvāṇa cannot be both existence and non-existence together: The very conception is absurd and self-contradictory — existence and non-existence are absolutely opposed like light and darkness.
- Nirvāṇa cannot be neither existence nor non-existence: Then it will not be conceived at all.

Hence if Nirvāṇa is neither existence nor non-existence nor both nor neither, it is only an appearance, not reality. Āryadeva, Chandrakīrti, and Śāntideva also condemn all world-objects to be mere illusions and appearances.

V. Mahāyāna-Sūtras: The Constructive Dialectic

The Shūnyavādin is NOT a Nihilist — The Essential Clarification

The Śūnyavādin is neither a thorough-going sceptic nor a cheap nihilist who doubts and denies the existence of everything for its own sake. His object is simply to show that all world-objects, when taken to be ultimately real, will be found self-contradictory and relative and hence mere appearances. True, he indulges in condemning all phenomena to be like illusion, dream, mirage, sky-flower, son of a barren woman — which suggests they are absolutely unreal. But this is NOT his real object. He does this only to emphasize the ultimate unreality of all phenomena.

Emphatically and repeatedly:

- He knows absolute negation is impossible because it necessarily presupposes affirmation.

- He only denies the ultimate reality of both affirmation and negation.
- He condemns intellect from the ultimate standpoint only — for he knows its authority is unquestionable in the empirical world.
- He wants us to rise above the categories and contradictions of intellect and embrace Reality.
- He asserts that it is the Real itself which appears.
- He maintains that Reality is immanent in appearances, yet transcends them all.
- He maintains Reality is the Non-dual Absolute, Blissful, beyond intellect, where all plurality is merged.

This is the constructive side of the dialectic in Śūnyavāda: here intellect is transformed into Pure Experience.

The Saddharma-puṇḍarīka: The Two Standpoints and the Path

As long as we are entangled in the categories of the intellect we are like blind-born men completely in the dark. When we reach the limit where finite thought confesses its weakness and points towards Reality, our blindness is cured — but our vision is still blurred. It is only when we embrace Pure Knowledge of the Buddha that we gain true vision. This is Reality which is Calm and Deep and Pure Knowledge, transcending intellect, to be directly realized through pure knowledge. It is the Most Excellent and Final Enlightenment (uttama agra bodhi) by which we become one with the Buddha.

The Six Perfections (Pāramitās) and the Supreme: Prajñā-pāramitā

There are six Perfections of which the last and highest is the Supreme or Perfect Knowledge (prajñā-pāramitā). The Aṣṭasāhasrikā Prajñāpāramitā declares it to be:

- Clear and transparent like the sky
- Devoid of plurality
- Beyond finite thought — Indescribable
- Divine Mother, One with the Buddha just as moonlight is one with the moon
- The Seal of the Law, the Light of Existence, the Trumpet of Religion, the Vision of the Doctrine, the Body of Bliss
- The only Path towards Liberation
- Reality itself — Indescribable and Unthinkable in the sense that intellect fails to describe it adequately. Here the cries of intellect are satisfied and its contradictions reconciled.
- Subtler than the subtle, profounder than the profound
- Where all desires and all doubts are set at rest

There are two standpoints:

- Empirical standpoint (Saṃvṛti / Vyavahāra): deals with categories of intellect (koṭi), name and form (nāma-rūpa), dependence (nimitta), relativity (vikalpa or saṅga), practical compromises (nāma-mātra), phenomena (vyavahāra or saṃvṛti).
- Absolute standpoint (Paramārtha): deals with Perfect Knowledge (prajñā-pāramitā), which is Non-dual (advaya), Independent (animitta), Real (sāra), and Absolute (paramārtha).

Ultimately it is the Real which appears. The Real is at once immanent and transcendent. The suchness of all dharmas is the suchness of Reality. The phenomenal is the noumenal and the noumenal is the phenomenal. Appearances are Reality. They are grounded in the Real, the Brahman, which at once transcends the duality of the relative and the absolute. From the absolute standpoint alone we realize the true nature of the world. The phenomenal must not be utterly condemned — intellect need not commit suicide, because it is from the phenomenal that we can go to the noumenal, from the lower to the higher.

We shall rise to the Absolute, not by denying the relative, but by transcending it with its own help. If a ship capsizes in the sea, those who catch hold of some small canoe or piece of wood or log or even a corpse will reach the shore; but those who will not are sure to be drowned. Similarly those who take the help of the True Doctrine, of Rational Faith, of the Six Perfections — however phenomenal they may ultimately be — will reach the Absolute, the safe, the immortal and blissful shore of Nirvāṇa. But those who deny the phenomenal will be surely drowned in it.

The Laṅkāvatāra on Reality as Spiritual Experience

The Laṅkāvatāra declares Reality to be Spiritual Experience which is beyond the categories of the intellect, beyond discrimination (vikalpa) and dualism (dvaita), and which can be directly realized by the Pure Knowledge of the Buddha. Buddhas become Enlightened by transcending the dualism of the intellect, by realizing the ultimate unreality of all objects (dharma-nairātmya) and of empirical subjects (pudgala-nairātmya), by removing the screen of suffering (kleśāvaraṇa) and ignorance in the form of objects covering the Real (jñeyāvaraṇa).

Reality is Silence. From that night when Buddha became Enlightened up to that night when he attained Nirvāṇa, not a single word was uttered by him. The teaching of Buddha is truly beyond language. He who teaches with words merely babbles — Reality is beyond language and intellect. The Buddha is beyond all plurality. And that which is beyond plurality is Reality, for it is beyond intellect. A finger is needed to point at the moon, but the finger itself should not be mistaken for the moon. Similarly the Absolute is preached through the phenomenal, but the phenomenal should not be mistaken for the Absolute. Ultimately even this distinction is transcended — Appearances are Reality. Like Saṃsāra and Nirvāṇa, all things are non-dual.

VI. Śūnyavāda: Nāgārjuna's Constructive Dialectic

A. Nāgārjuna's Definition of Reality (Tattva)

Nāgārjuna defines Reality (tattva) as that which can only be directly realized, that which is Calm and Blissful, that where all plurality is merged, that where all cries of intellect are satisfied, that which is the Non-dual Absolute. Buddha's teaching relates to two aspects of Truth:

- Saṃvṛti or Vyavahāra (conventional/empirical truth): a sort of 'covering', hiding the real truth; a workable reality, a practical makeshift, a necessary compromise. In the end it is no truth at all — but this can be realized only from the absolute standpoint. It is ignorance (avidyā) or delusion (moha) which covers Reality and gives a false view. It is the empirical truth which is means (upāya); the absolute truth is the end (upeya).
- Paramārtha (absolute truth): those who do not know these two standpoints cannot understand the teaching of the Buddha. Saṃvṛti is a distinction within and by finite thought itself, yet it has got to be transcended. Intellect must be transformed into Spiritual Experience.

The phenomenal cannot be condemned by its own logic. A dreamer, while he is dreaming, cannot condemn his own dream. Pure negation is an impossibility — it necessarily presupposes affirmation. Even an illusion, a mirage, a dream, a reflection, as such exists. Appearances are not to be utterly condemned because it is only through the lower that we can go to the higher.

B. The Double Aspect of Śūnyatā in Nāgārjuna's Constructive Account

Nāgārjuna explains that Śūnyatā has a double aspect:

- Phenomenal aspect — Svabhāva-śūnyatā or Nissvabhāvatā: Appearances are devoid of ultimate reality. It is Pratītyasamutpāda or Relativity. Everything grasped by the intellect is necessarily relative. It is the Madhyama-mārga (Middle Path) between affirmation and negation, a Path that ultimately transcends both.
- Absolute aspect — Reality itself: Śūnyatā in its second aspect is Reality itself wherein all plurality is merged and all categories of intellect are transcended. Absolutely speaking, Reality is neither Śūnya nor Aśūnya nor both nor neither. It is called Śūnya only from the empirical standpoint.

In the phenomenal world, Relativity reigns supreme — what is not relative is for intellect as good as nothing. But we should not take Relativity itself as the final truth. To do so is to refuse to rise above the phenomenal. Relativity itself is relative — it is related to the Absolute without which it loses all meaning. The Buddhas have preached Śūnyatā in order to enable us to rise above all the entangling categories of the intellect.

Those who take Śūnyatā in the sense of a category of intellect, in the sense of affirmation or negation or both or neither, are incorrigible and hopeless and are destined to doom. — Chandrakīrti, quoting Ratnakūṭa-Sūtra

Medical analogy: A doctor administers a very strong purgative to a patient of constipation. That purgative, after throwing all impurities out of the abdomen, should itself also come out. If that strong purgative does not itself come out but remains in the abdomen, is the person cured? Similarly, Śūnyatā, if wrongly understood in the sense of any category of intellect, will sound the philosophical death-knell. Like a snake carelessly caught, it will bite; like wrong knowledge creating havoc, or tantra wrongly practised, it will destroy. Knowing that Śūnyatā cannot be easily grasped, the Buddha just after his Enlightenment became silent and uninclined towards teaching. But if rightly understood, Śūnyatā itself is Nirvāṇa.

C. The Seven Kinds of Śūnyatā — and the Highest

Of the seven kinds of Śūnyatā, mere negation is the worst (sarvajaghanyā). The best is the Paramārthāryajñānamahā-śūnyatā — the Absolute itself that can be realized by Pure Experience which follows the knowledge that all things are essentially inexpressible (sarvadharmānirabhilāpya-śūnyatā).

Existence and non-existence, purity and impurity, etc., says the Samādhirāja Sūtra, are the cries of intellect. The 'Middle Path' avoids the errors of both these extremes and at once transcends the extremes as well as the middle itself.

D. The Practical Path: Four Meditations, Three Samādhis, Ten Stages of Bodhisattvahood

The practical way by which intellect is transformed into Spiritual Experience is indicated by four Meditations (dhyānas), three Samādhis, and ten stages of Bodhisattvahood:

The Four Meditations (Dhyānas)

- First Dhyāna: Working of intellect (savitarka, savichāra) + pleasure (prīti, sukha).
- Second Dhyāna: Intellect is in the process of giving place to Vision (avitarka, avichāra) and pleasure gives way to higher happiness (samādhijapṛīti-sukha, ātma-samprasāda).
- Third Dhyāna: Intellect ceases (avichārā); only higher happiness (niṣpṛītika) remains.
- Fourth Dhyāna: Intellect becomes one with Experience; pain and pleasure are transcended (aduḥkhāsukha); a unique bliss (vihāra) arises.

The Three Samādhis

- First (Śūnyatā-samādhi): We know the phenomenal is devoid of ultimate reality (svabhāva-śūnya) and that Reality is devoid of plurality (prapañcha-śūnya).

- Second (Animitta-samādhi): We know the real cause of everything; we know it is the Real itself which through Ignorance appears as the world of plurality.
- Third (Apraṇihita-samādhi): We directly embrace Reality which transcends the categories of the intellect.

The Ten Stages (Bhūmis) of Bodhisattvahood

- 1st — Pramuditā: Bodhisattva, realizing inability of intellect, begins with great pleasure his quest for true knowledge.
- 2nd — Vimalā: Acquires the ten noble deeds.
- 3rd — Prābhākari: Knows subject-object duality and categories of intellect to be unreal.
- 4th — Archiṣmatī: All doubts and cries of intellect are set at rest.
- 5th — Sudurjayā: Understands the empirical and absolute points of view.
- 6th — Abhimukhī: The Ego is conquered and Dependent Origination is fully understood.
- 7th — Dūraṅgamā: Śūnyatā in its double aspect is fully realized.
- 8th — Achalā: Absolute non-duality of appearances and Reality is realized.
- 9th — Sādhumatī: Constant contact with Reality is attained.
- 10th — Dharma-meghā: Becomes one with the Real, the Absolute, and like an heir-apparent is consecrated with 'Pure Knowledge'. He then defers his Nirvāṇa in order to liberate others.

The Bodhisattva carries suffering humanity in the Great Ship of the True Doctrine from the stormy sea of birth-and-death to the eternal and blissful shore of Nirvāṇa. He makes the people burning with suffering cool by the showers of knowledge. He blows the Trumpet of the True Law and the Conch of the True Doctrine; he lights the Torch of the Divine Truth and rains showers of the Sacred Religion. If one does not understand the truth, it is his fault — not the fault of the teacher, nor of the doctrine, just as if a patient does not take the medicine, it is his fault, not the fault of the doctor nor of the medicine.

E. The Saṃsāra-Nirvāṇa Identity

What is called the phenomenal world or the cycle of birth-and-death from the empirical standpoint, viewed through the glasses of Causation and Relativity, that very world is called Nirvāṇa or the Absolute from the ultimate standpoint, viewed without Causation and Relativity. Bondage, viewed *sub specie aeternitatis*, is Liberation. The Absolute is its appearances. There is not the slightest difference between Saṃsāra and Nirvāṇa. Those who want to bring the non-dual Buddha within the four categories of the intellect cannot realize the Tathāgata, entangled as they are in the meshes of plurality. The essential nature of all objects, like Nirvāṇa, is beyond production and destruction.

When this truth is realized, the subject-object duality is transcended and the cries of intellect are satisfied. Intellect is transformed into realization. Philosophy is equated with silence. From the absolute standpoint, to no person, at no place, no doctrine was ever taught by the Buddha. He descended to the phenomenal level out of compassion for all beings. Reality cannot be realized by negating appearances — we can rise to the higher only through the lower. We cannot give even an idea of the Absolute without the help of the phenomenal.

He who has realized the truth of Śūnyatā realizes the meaning and significance of everything and can explain everything. On the other hand, he who has not realized the truth of Śūnyatā fails to realize the meaning and significance of anything and can explain nothing.

VII. Nāgārjuna's Refutation of Opponents — The Vighraha-Vyāvarttanī

Nāgārjuna in his Vighraha-Vyāvarttanī gives the anticipated objections of opponents against Śūnyatā and then refutes all of them. The core three-part objection and Nāgārjuna's reply:

Objection (a): Śūnyatā which denies the existence of all dharmas is not true, because:

- The arguments used for the existence of Śūnyatā are also unreal;
- If they are not unreal, they undermine the Śūnyavādin's own premises — for then he at least maintains the reality of his arguments;
- And Śūnyavāda has no pramāṇa (means of cognition) to establish itself.

Nāgārjuna's Three-Part Reply:

- Reply to (a): The ultimate unreality of words and arguments does not render Śūnyatā unreal. By Śūnyatā we do not mean mere negation; by it we mean Dependent Origination or Relativity. Our arguments do not undermine our own premises. We do not say: 'This particular argument of ours is true while all others are false.' We say: 'All arguments are ultimately unreal.' Absolutely speaking, we have no thesis to prove and hence no words and no arguments — how can we then be charged with defects? But from the empirical standpoint we admit the reality of arguments because the phenomenal cannot be condemned by its own logic.
- Reply to (b): The validity of pramāṇas themselves cannot be established. A means of cognition (pramāṇa), like fire, cannot prove itself. If fire can enkindle itself, it will also burn itself. A pramāṇa cannot be established by another pramāṇa — it will lead to infinite regress. A pramāṇa cannot be proved by an object of cognition (prameya). The opponent admits that a prameya is to be proved by pramāṇas; if he now admits that pramāṇas in their turn are to be proved by prameyas, his argument amounts to a laughable position: a father begets a son; now that son in

his turn should beget his own father. A pramāṇa cannot be proved at random. The validity of pramāṇas, therefore, can be established neither by themselves, nor by other pramāṇas, nor by prameyas, nor by accident.

- Reply to (c): Reality is above refutation and non-refutation. We do not negate anything. There is nothing which can be negated. Even the charge that the Śūnyavādin negates everything is made by our opponent. We, however, go beyond affirmation and negation.

The Three-Level Teaching in the Ratnāvalī

Nāgārjuna says in his Ratnāvalī that just as a learned grammarian may teach even the alphabets, similarly Buddha taught according to the capacity of his disciples:

- To ordinary people: taught affirmation so that they may avoid all evil deeds.
- To mediocres: taught negation so that they may realize the unreality of the ego. (Both these are based on duality.)
- To the best: taught the blissful Śūnya — the deeper truth, terrible to the fools but kind to the wise.

Nāgārjuna condemns nihilism (nāstikya) by saying:

- Negation leads to hell.
- Affirmation leads to heaven.
- Non-dual truth which transcends affirmation and negation leads to liberation.

This Pure Knowledge where affirmation and negation, good and evil, heaven and hell are merged is called Liberation by the wise. From the absolute standpoint we have no thesis, no morality, no intellect — because they are all grounded in Pure Knowledge (bodhi), the Reality. Negation is possible only as a destruction or as an antithesis of affirmation. But when there is no affirmation, how can there be negation? Synthesis alone is real. Both thesis and antithesis are appearances. The universe is therefore neither real nor unreal, and hence only an appearance.

The Nihilist vs. the Mādhyamika — A Crucial Distinction

People, says Nāgārjuna, not understanding the meaning of Śūnya, accuse us of nihilism. The distinction is clear and fundamental:

- If everything is Aśūnya (absolutely real), then there should be no dependent origination, no production, no destruction, no bondage, no liberation, no Noble Truths, no Order, no Religion, no Buddha. Everything, being real, should be eternal and motionless. Then there should be no change, no motion, no world. Those who maintain absolute reality of world-objects undermine the distinction between the relative and the absolute and lose even the phenomenal.
- If everything is Śūnya in the sense of absolute negation, then the world cannot be called even an appearance. Verily the hare's horn does not even appear. Absolute negation is an impossibility — it must logically presuppose affirmation. Again, if

everything is Śūnya in the sense of being relative, then too there is no production, no destruction, no bondage, no liberation — because Relativity itself is relative; it is related to the Absolute without which it becomes meaningless.

The Śūnyavādins take Śūnyatā in its double aspect: phenomena are essentially relative and therefore ultimately unreal; and Reality is the Non-dual Absolute where all plurality is merged. Therefore they alone can truly understand and explain the reality and the worth of all appearances, together with their intellectual, ethical, and religious implications.

Analogy: Suppose a person has committed theft. Now a man, not knowing this, gives evidence simply prompted by enemies of the thief, that that person is the thief. Another man who caught the thief flagrante delicto also gives evidence to the same effect. The evidence in both cases is the same. But the former man is a liar even though he has unintentionally spoken the truth, while the latter is truthful because he knows and has intentionally told the truth. The difference between the nihilist and the Mādhyamika is the difference between the former and the latter. — Chandrakīrti

Moreover, the nihilist, in a self-contradictory manner, denies everything, while the Mādhyamika admits the empirical reality of everything. It is only from the absolute standpoint that he declares the phenomenal to be unreal. Thus his doctrine transcends affirmation as well as negation. Śūnyatā, from this standpoint, because it is devoid of all plurality, is Nirvāṇa itself.

VIII. Chandrakīrti's Critique of Diñnāga and Buddhist Logic

The Two Mādhyamika Sub-Schools

Two sub-schools of Mādhyamika emerge over the question of logic's status:

- Prāsaṅgika-Mādhyamika (Buddhapālita, supported by Chandrakīrti): Logic is condemned as a hindrance rather than a help for the Mādhyamika system. Logic has only negative value — we only refute the theory of our opponent without accepting the converse view. Our words are not policemen; they cannot arrest us. They simply enable us to express something. Ultimately every argument is either unreal (asiddha) or self-contradictory (viruddha).
- Svatantra-Mādhyamika (Bhāvaviveka, Diñnāga): Wants to support Śūnyavāda by independent reasoning. Diñnāga maintains that knowledge is the result of constructive thought and pure sensation; words are relational and can give us only the universal (sāmānya), not the Real, which is a unique momentary particular (svalakṣaṇa) realizable by self-consciousness (svasamvitti) — the indescribable Real.

Chandrakīrti's Objection to Diñnāga's Self-Consciousness of the Svalakṣaṇa

Chandrakīrti points out that Diñnāga's Svalakṣaṇa cannot be self-conscious. He quotes a passage from the Ratnachūḍa-parīṣṭhā: consciousness cannot apprehend itself just as the edge of a sword cannot cut itself or the tip of a finger cannot touch itself. Both subject and object are relative and therefore ultimately unreal. If fire can enkindle itself, it will equally burn itself.

Furthermore, the Svalakṣaṇa cannot be called indescribable (avāchya) — it is not like our Śūnya. For us, Reality is indescribable because no category of intellect can adequately describe it. Intellect always proceeds with dichotomy and is forced to land in antinomies — ultimately both thesis and antithesis are unreal. Diñnāga wants both to be viewed as indescribable, but this is impossible: the Svalakṣaṇa cannot be regarded as an absolute reality because of the momentariness and the plurality of these so-called reals — it is as relative as any universal. In fact it involves a double relation, that of sense and thought, and that of 'in-itself' and 'not in-itself'. A 'thing-in-itself' loses all meaning unless contrasted with a thing which is 'not in-itself'. Both Svalakṣaṇa and Sāmānyalakṣaṇa are correlatives; what is relative is only an appearance, not Reality.

Although Diñnāga apparently accepts the distinction between the phenomenal and the absolute by admitting the absolute reality of the Svalakṣaṇa, yet really he is undermining this distinction by his transcendental logic. His Svalakṣaṇa is not absolute but only relative. Hence Diñnāga does not have even the phenomenal reality — because without an Absolute, the phenomenal itself ceases to be phenomenal. This distinction is fundamental and must be maintained, otherwise we lose even the phenomenal.

Chandrakīrti's Positive Account: The Relation of Phenomenal to Absolute

From the absolute standpoint we declare the phenomenal to be a mere appearance — but by doing so we do not undermine its empirical reality. Even the Buddha has preached his doctrine from the phenomenal point of view according to our common logic.

The Samvṛti has two aspects within the phenomenal reality itself:

- Tathyaśamvṛti (phenomenally true): Things recognized as real by persons with rightly functioning sense-organs.
- Mithyāśamvṛti (phenomenally false): Things perceived when sense-organs are not properly functioning — things in a dream, a mirage, hair in the atmosphere, double-moon, etc.

Thus Chandrakīrti recognizes the Pratibhāsa and the Vyavahāra of Vedānta by splitting Samvṛti into two. Ultimately however, everything phenomenal, because

relative, is unreal. From this standpoint Reality is equated with silence. But because the distinction between the phenomenal and the absolute is itself not absolute, Reality from the phenomenal standpoint is heard and preached. Chandrakīrti compares phenomena to a staircase in which each step is higher — through which we reach the Palace of Reality. The empirical truth is means (upāya); the absolute truth is the end (upeya).

Chandrakīrti's Own Position: Pure Negation is Impossible

Chandrakīrti replies to the objection that his argument is itself ultimately unreal or self-contradictory: this objection is valid only against those who give independent status to reasoning. For the Mādhyamika, logic has only phenomenal validity. We simply repudiate the arguments of our opponents. We have no thesis of our own to prove. We are not positively proving that every argument is either unreal or self-contradictory — we cannot do so. We accept the empirical reality of logic, but it is a reality which ultimately undermines itself. From the absolute point of view, Reality is silence. But we descend to the phenomenal and point out that the opponent's thesis cannot be supported even by his own logic. We have no thesis of our own — we only demonstrate negatively that every argument is ultimately unreal because self-contradictory. Criticism of all views is itself not a view; rejection of all theories is itself not a theory.

From the absolute standpoint: no thesis to prove, no belief to uphold, no assertion to maintain — simply because Reality is beyond all duality, beyond all theses and anti-theses, beyond all belief and doubt, beyond all assertion and denial. We do not maintain any belief for the simple reason that we do not have any doubt. Belief and doubt are correlatives. One is the thesis; the other is the antithesis. One is impossible without the other. And because we do not have any doubt, we cannot have any belief. Ultimately silence is the highest philosophy.

Chandrakīrti vehemently criticizes Diñnāga's Svatantra-Vijñānavāda School. He says the efforts of Buddhist logicians to improve on the Naiyāyikas are futile. Logic has, after all, only phenomenal reality. If the cognition of objects depends upon the means of cognition (pramāṇa), then upon what do these pramāṇas themselves depend?

IX. Śāntideva — The Last Great Philosopher of Śūnyavāda

The Bodhi-chitta and Universal Compassion

Śāntideva in his much-inspired Bodhicharyāvatāra praises the Bodhi-chitta or the True Self which is Pure Consciousness. He who wants to overcome the manifold miseries of this world, who wants to remove the innumerable sufferings of all beings,

and who wants to enjoy immeasurable happiness, should never cease to direct his thought towards Supreme Enlightenment. The realization of the True Self which is Pure Knowledge can at once turn an impure mortal into the Pure Buddha.

Śāntideva's ethical argument for universal compassion:

When all other beings, like myself, like happiness and hate fear and pain, then what is the difference between my 'ego' and their 'ego' that I should protect myself and not others? We must defer our Nirvāṇa for the sake of the liberation of other beings. If we are ready to sacrifice everything for the benefit of humanity, if we earnestly work for the salvation of all beings, then oceans of bliss will be for us which will far excel the so-called pleasure of selfish and individual liberation.

Śāntideva on the Two Aspects of Truth and Degrees of Realization

Truth has two aspects — the conditional and the absolute. The Absolute is the transcendent which is beyond finite intellect; the conditional is the finite intellect itself. The conditional is contradicted by the absolute, but not vice versa. Even among philosopher-saints there are degrees. The higher sublates the lower. These degrees represent different stages in the development from intellect to spiritual realization.

We deny only the ultimate reality, not the relative existence, of phenomena. But we do not stop here. Afterwards we transcend even Relativity itself. By transcending Relativity we transcend intellect itself. When there is neither affirmation nor negation, intellect, finding no categories for its support, merges in the Absolute.

Śāntideva on the Two Kinds of Ignorance and Śūnyatā as Pure Knowledge

Ignorance is of two kinds:

- Kleśāvaraṇa: Ignorance due to suffering — the screen of defilement (passions, desires) covering the self.
- Jñeyāvaraṇa: Ignorance in the form of objects covering the Real — the screen of knowables, i.e., the intellect's tendency to reify phenomena.

Śūnyatā is the antithesis of Ignorance of both kinds. It is Pure Knowledge. As long as the duality of the subject and the object is not transcended, neither Bhikṣutā (the state of a true monk) nor Nirvāṇa can be realized.

Why should one fear Śūnyatā which really removes all fears?

The phenomenal must be accepted as a practical necessity — just as a person who desires to fetch water must have some vessel, similarly he who wants to rise to Nirvāṇa must accept the phenomenal as relatively real. Ultimately there are no degrees of truth and Reality. But phenomenally they exist. We shall rise to the

Absolute not by denying the phenomenal but by transcending it.

Āryadeva (Śāntideva's predecessor): Reality is the Pure Self (chitta). In its real nature it is above discrimination, absolutely pure, unoriginated, uncontaminated, and self-luminous. On account of Ignorance it appears as intellect — even as a white marble appears coloured on account of a coloured object placed near it. The Jewel of Self appears to be fouled with the mud of Ignorance. Ignorance (avidyā) is error (bhrānti). Just as when 'shell' is known the 'shell-silver' vanishes, when 'rope' is known the 'rope-snake' vanishes — similarly when knowledge dawns, ignorance vanishes.

X. Master Glossary — Key Terms of Śūnyavāda

- Advaya-tattva — Non-dual Reality; the Absolute in which all plurality is merged. Also called Niṣprapañcha.
- Anutpāda — No-origination — Nāgārjuna's opening thesis: nothing can be produced from itself, from another, from both, or from neither.
- Aśūnya — Absolute fullness — the opposite of mere negation. Reality is neither Śūnya nor Aśūnya from the absolute standpoint.
- Bhūtatahatā — Suchness as ultimate Existence — one of Aśvaghoṣa's names for Reality/Tathatā.
- Catuṣkoṭi — The four categories of intellect: existence, non-existence, both, neither. Reality transcends all four.
- Dharma-nairātmya — Unreality of all elements/dharmas — Mahāyāna's advance beyond Hīnayāna's mere pudgala-nairātmya.
- Dharmakāya — The Harmonious Whole; Reality viewed as universal Body of the Buddha.
- Jñeyāvaraṇa — The screen of knowables — Ignorance in the form of objects covering the Real. One of the two kinds of Ignorance.
- Kleśāvaraṇa — The screen of defilements — Ignorance due to passions and suffering. The other kind of Ignorance.
- Mādhyamika — Follower of the Middle Path (Madhyama-mārga); the Śūnyavādin's self-designation, avoiding eternalism and nihilism.
- Nāma-rūpa — Name and form — conventional categories of the empirical standpoint (Saṃvṛti).
- Paramārtha — Absolute truth — the second of the two standpoints; transcends Saṃvṛti; equivalent to spiritual experience (prajñā).
- Prajñā-pāramitā — Perfect/Supreme Knowledge — the sixth and highest pāramitā; non-dual, beyond intellect, Reality itself.
- Prapañcha-śūnya — Devoid of plurality — what Reality is; Śūnya in its absolute aspect.
- Pratītyasamutpāda — Dependent Origination / Relativity — Śūnya in its empirical aspect; the law of conditioned arising.
- Prāsaṅgika — Sub-school of Mādhyamika (Buddhapālita/Chandrakīrti) that rejects independent logic as a tool for Śūnyavāda.

- **Pudgala-nairātmya** — Unreality of the personal self — the limit reached by Hīnayāna; Mahāyāna goes further to dharma-nairātmya.
- **Samādhirāja Sūtra** — A key Mahāyāna text declaring existence/non-existence, purity/impurity as 'cries of intellect'.
- **Samvṛti** — Conventional/empirical truth; also means 'covering' (hiding the real nature of things). Subdivided by Chandrakīrti into Tathyaśamvṛti and Mithyāśamvṛti.
- **Svabhāva-śūnya** — Devoid of ultimate reality / own-nature — what appearances are; Śūnya in its empirical aspect. Also nissvabhāva or anātman.
- **Svalakṣaṇa** — The unique momentary particular — Dīnnāga's candidate for the indescribable Real, rejected by Chandrakīrti as itself relative.
- **Svatantra-Mādhyamika** — Sub-school (Bhāvaviveka/Dīnnāga) that tries to establish Śūnyavāda through independent positive reasoning.
- **Tathāgatagarbha** — The Buddha-womb; Reality as Bliss of infinite merits; the potentiality of Buddhahood in all beings.
- **Tathatā** — Suchness — Aśvaghoṣa's supreme name for Reality; neither Śūnya nor Aśūnya nor both nor neither.
- **Vyavahāra** — Conventional usage/practice — the phenomenal standpoint; practically valid but ultimately grounded in and pointing to Paramārtha.

Notes compiled from C. D. Sharma, A Critical Survey of Indian Philosophy, Chapter Six. All philosophical arguments follow Sharma's dialectical presentation. For scholarly use.